

GREEN & GATHER RESTAURANTS LLC

Franchise Operations Manual

Section 7 — Allergen Handling

Revision	March 2025
Replaces	Section 7, June 2023
Owner	Director of Food Safety & Quality, Green & Gather Support Center
Applies to	All corporate-operated and franchised locations in the New York City, Austin and Chicago markets
Review cycle	Annual, or on any change to menu, supplier or preparation method
Distribution	General Managers, Kitchen Managers, Franchise Operating Partners

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7.1 Purpose and scope

Food allergies are the single most serious food safety risk in a Green & Gather kitchen. A guest with a severe allergy can experience a life-threatening reaction from a quantity of allergen too small to see. This section sets out how every team member in every location talks to guests about allergens, how the kitchen prepares an order for a guest who has declared an allergy, and when to involve a manager.

This section applies to all team members, in all positions, in all markets. Franchise Operating Partners are responsible for training their teams on this section and for maintaining training records as described in 7.9.

7.2 The nine major allergens

United States law identifies nine major food allergens. Green & Gather declares each of these for every item on the menu, based on the ingredients used in that item's standard build:

Allergen	Where it typically appears on our menu
Milk	Cheeses, yogurt drizzle, ranch, honey butter, buffalo sauce
Egg	Ranch, caesar base
Fish	Anchovy in the caesar base
Crustacean shellfish	Not used as an ingredient
Tree nuts	Not used as an ingredient
Peanuts	Not used as an ingredient
Wheat	Flour tortillas, farro, miso, soy sauce, chili crisp, tamarind-lime sauce
Soy	Tofu, miso, soy sauce, chili crisp, buffalo sauce, tamarind-lime sauce
Sesame	Tahini sauces and dressings, sesame seeds, sesame oil, chili crisp

The allergen declaration for each menu item is printed on the current Allergen Reference Card at the order point and published on the nutrition website. Team members must answer allergen questions from the current card, never from memory.

7.3 Front-of-house allergen intake script

Use this script every time a guest mentions an allergy, an intolerance, or asks whether an item is "safe." Do not improvise around it. The words matter.

- 1. Acknowledge and identify.** *"Thank you for letting me know. Which allergy is it, so I can check the right information for you?"*
- 2. Check the card.** Look up the item on the current Allergen Reference Card. Do not answer before you have looked.
- 3. State the declared allergens.** *"The [item] is made with ingredients that contain [allergens from the card]."* If the card shows none of the guest's allergen: *"The [item] doesn't have [allergen] listed as an ingredient."*

4. Give the kitchen disclosure. *"I do want you to know that our kitchens use shared prep surfaces, shared utensils and a shared fryer, so we take extra steps for allergy orders, but we can't guarantee there's been no contact."*

5. Flag the order. Mark the ticket ALLERGY — [allergen] and tell the kitchen lead verbally.

6. Offer the manager. *"Would you like to speak with our manager before you order?"* For any severe allergy (see 7.7) the manager is called regardless of the guest's answer.

Never use the words "safe," "allergen-free," or "you'll be fine." Never guess. If the card does not answer the question, escalate under 7.7.

7.4 Menu guidance and substitutions

Most dietary needs can be met from the standard menu. The following substitutions are available on guest request at all locations and must be entered as modifiers so the kitchen sees them on the ticket:

- **Protein:** any protein may be swapped for grilled chicken, marinated tofu or braised chickpeas, or omitted.
- **Grain:** brown rice, quinoa and farro are interchangeable on any bowl. Remind guests that farro is a wheat grain.
- **Sauce or dressing:** any sauce may be swapped for another, served on the side, or omitted. Remind guests that the tahini-based sauces contain sesame.
- **Gluten-free wrap substitution is available on guest request at all locations.** Gluten-free tortillas are held in the reach-in below the wrap station in a sealed, labelled sleeve. Change gloves, use a fresh sheet of deli paper on the press, and build the wrap on that paper rather than on the board. Ring it as the standard wrap with the GF modifier; there is no upcharge.
- **Dairy:** cheese, yogurt drizzle, ranch and honey butter may be omitted. Note that the buffalo sauce contains milk and cannot be made dairy-free.

Substitutions do not change the kitchen disclosure in 7.3 step 4. A guest who receives a substituted item still receives the disclosure.

7.5 Prep station separation procedure for allergy orders

When a ticket is flagged ALLERGY, the kitchen lead is responsible for the order from start to hand-off. Green & Gather kitchens do not have dedicated allergen-free equipment or a separate allergen prep area, so the procedure relies on sequence and cleaning rather than separation of space.

1. **Stop and read.** The kitchen lead reads the ticket aloud, naming the allergen, before any ingredient is touched.
2. **Clear and clean.** Wipe down the assembly area with a fresh sanitizer towel from the red bucket. Discard the towel; do not return it to the bucket.
3. **Fresh hands, fresh tools.** Wash hands, put on new gloves, and take clean utensils and a clean board from the dish pass. Do not use utensils already on the line, even if they look clean.
4. **Fresh product where possible.** Portion from unopened or back-up containers rather than from the line pans, which may have been cross-dipped during service.
5. **Build first, build alone.** The allergy order is built before other orders on the same ticket, and nothing else is built on that surface until it is complete.

6. **Fryer and press.** Every location runs one fryer, one griddle and one wrap press. These are shared by all items and cleaned on the shift schedule, not between orders. Any item that passes through the fryer, griddle or press cannot be protected by this procedure. Tell the guest.
7. **Hand-off.** The kitchen lead hands the order directly to the team member serving the guest, with the allergen named aloud. The order does not sit in the pass.

Colour-coded boards in our kitchens indicate protein type (raw poultry, cooked protein, produce), *not* allergen status. Do not describe a board to a guest as "the allergen board."

7.6 In-store and commissary preparation

Team members are often asked whether an item is "made here." Guests with allergies ask because it tells them who to trust. Answer accurately.

Made in store, every day

- **Guacamole** is made in store each morning from whole avocados, lime, red onion, cilantro and salt, and again mid-afternoon as needed. It is never delivered pre-made. Because it is made on the produce station it is subject to the same shared-surface disclosure as everything else.
- **Quick pickles** (cucumber and red onion) are made in house. The brine is sweetened with honey, so the pickles are vegetarian but not vegan.
- **Brown rice, quinoa and farro** are cooked in store daily.
- **Vegetables** arrive washed and are cut, roasted or charred in store.
- **Proteins** arrive pre-cooked from the supplier and are portioned to order.

Delivered sealed from the commissary

- All **saucers and dressings** — tahini-harissa, lemon-tahini, buffalo, ranch, the caesar base, the yogurt drizzle and the miso-ginger dressing — are produced at the Green & Gather commissary and delivered sealed. The allergen profile on the commissary label is the profile of the sealed product. Once the container is opened on the line, the shared-surface disclosure applies.
- The **tamarind-lime sauce** and **chili crisp** are purchased finished from approved suppliers and delivered sealed. Their allergen declarations come from the supplier specification, which is held by the Support Center Supply Chain team.
- **Flour tortillas** are purchased finished from an approved bakery.

If a guest asks about a supplier's manufacturing practices, for example whether a sauce is made in a nut-free facility, do not answer from the Allergen Reference Card. The card covers ingredients only. Escalate under 7.7 so the manager can check the supplier specification.

7.7 Escalation: when to involve a manager

Call the manager on duty to the guest, before the order is placed, in any of the following situations:

- The guest describes a severe or anaphylactic allergy, mentions an epinephrine auto-injector, or is ordering for a child with a declared allergy.
- The guest asks about supplier practices, shared facilities or "may contain" risk for any ingredient.
- The guest asks for dedicated equipment, a separate fryer or a separate prep area. We do not have these; the manager explains why and helps the guest choose.

- The Allergen Reference Card does not answer the question, or the item has been modified in a way the card does not cover.
- The guest reports a reaction, in store or after leaving (see 7.8).
- The team member is unsure for any reason.

A manager who cannot answer a question with confidence from the card or the supplier specification tells the guest so, and helps them choose a different item. "I don't know" followed by a safer choice is the correct answer. A reassuring guess is a breach of this section.

7.8 Reporting a reaction

If a guest reports an allergic reaction, in store or afterwards:

1. If the guest is in distress, call emergency services first. Do not wait for a manager.
2. The manager on duty records the item ordered, any modifiers, the time of service, the time and description of the reaction, and the guest's contact details, on the Allergen Incident Form (Appendix 7-A).
3. Retain any remaining product from the same containers used for the order, labelled with the date and time, until released by the Support Center.
4. Report to the Director of Food Safety & Quality by phone the same day, and submit the form within 24 hours.
5. Do not discuss cause or fault with the guest. Express concern, take the details, and hand off to the Support Center.

7.9 Training and sign-off

Every team member completes allergen training before their first shift and annually thereafter. Kitchen leads and managers complete the extended module, which includes a practical run-through of 7.5. Franchise Operating Partners keep the signed training log (Appendix 7-B) on site for inspection. A location with any team member out of date on allergen training may not open for service.